

Kindergarten Neurodiversity Lesson Plans by Cocoon Corner

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Stanford Neurodiversity Project

Neurodiversity Concept

Time: 35 mins

Day 1

- Core Message: "Neurodiversity" means that all our brains are different, and that's a good thing.
- Summary: Introduces neurodiversity by teaching students that every brain works uniquely. Dedicating Day One to this foundational concept gives kids a simple, lasting baseline for understanding individual differences all week.

Summary

Materials

1. Projector / TV & Audio (to play the All My Stripes storybook video) or book
2. Chart Paper or Whiteboard + Markers (for the class KWL Chart warm-up)
3. [Zebra Worksheet](#) (1 copy per student)
4. Crayons / Markers / Colored Pencils

Warm-up: KWL Chart (7 mins)

What is neurodiversity?

- NEUROlogy is the study of brains. A NEUROsurgeon is a doctor for brains. What do you think the "neuro" part of this word means?
- DIVERSE means having many different kinds of things together (like a garden with lots of different flowers, or a fruit bowl with different fruits). What do you think the "diversity" part of this word means?

As a class, students share ideas to fill in a blank **Know-Wonder-Learn organizer** on large chart paper or a whiteboard. It's okay if the kids aren't sure. Ask them to make wild guesses in order to pique their curiosity!

1

Storybook Video: "All My Stripes" (5 mins)

Play the following video to the four-minute mark: **All My Stripes: A Story for Children with Autism, read by Shaina Rudolph and Danielle Royer**

2

Storybook Discussion: Unique Stripes (8 mins)

Ask questions about the book:

1. Zane was worried that his 'autism stripe' was the only one people would notice. What are some of Zane's other amazing stripes?
2. If all zebras had the exact same stripes, would they be as beautiful or as interesting?
3. What is one unique 'stripe' you have? (The instructor should offer an example to begin. Ex: One of my stripes is that I'm fantastic at baking cupcakes!)
4. Why is it awesome that we all have different stripes in our classroom?

3



Day 1 cont.

Drawing Activity: Zebra Stripes (15 mins)

Drawing Activity: Zebra stripes!

4

- Each student will complete the zebra worksheet linked above.
- Students will decorate their zebras with what makes them unique. For example, a student who loves rocket ships and eating cupcakes could draw a rocket ship and a cupcake.
- Towards the end, reinforce that the unique “stripes” of each student’s zebra demonstrate neurodiversity.
- Students can then share their zebras with each other.



Equality and Fairness (accommodations)

Time: 40 minutes

Day 2

- **Core Message:** "Fair means giving everyone what they NEED, not giving everyone the SAME thing."
- **Summary:** This day builds on Day 1 by connecting different brain needs to the concepts of equity and fairness, teaching kids why individual accommodations are necessary.

Summary

Materials

1. Projector / TV & Audio (to play Fair is Fair) or purchase book
2. Optional: Band-aids or Stickers (to demonstrate giving everyone what they need vs. the exact same thing)

Warm-Up Check-In: Same vs. Need (7 mins)

Begin with questions:

- If one person is cold, should everyone wear a jacket?
- If one person can't see the board, should everyone get glasses?
- If one person is hungry, should we all eat again?

Have students answer these questions and transition to introducing the topic of needs and equality in neurodivergence. Display the fence image attached to the slideshow.

- Sometimes giving everyone the SAME thing isn't actually fair.
- FAIR means giving everyone what they NEED.
- Link to Day 1 lesson: Some people need different things to learn or feel comfortable because we all have different brains.

1

Read storybook (8 mins)

Play: Fair is Fair by Sonny Varela

2

Game: Fair or Not Fair? (10 mins)

Game: Fair or not Fair?

- Hare gets a handful of food, Giraffe gets a wheelbarrow of food, and Elephant gets a truckload of food.
 - Fair
- Hare, Giraffe, and Elephant each get a wheelbarrow of food.
 - Not fair
- Giraffe gets a tall water bucket and Hare gets a short water bowl.
 - Fair
- A kid who can't see the board gets glasses.
 - Fair

3



Day 2 cont.

	• Everyone gets the same size shoes. ◦ Not fair • A kid who takes longer to finish worksheets gets more time to finish her worksheet. ◦ Fair • Everyone gets the same amount of time to finish their worksheet. ◦ Not fair What does fairness mean?
Demonstration (15 mins)	Band-aid activity! This lesson is from Empowering Education (here). We recommend that instructors review the linked PDF before leading this lesson. Below is a summary of this activity. • Call up the first volunteer. Ask them to tell the class what their chosen injury is. ◦ Example injuries include: a. I scraped my arm at recess (requires a Band-Aid) b. I broke my arm falling off my bike c. A zombie bit me d. Any other silly or realistic injury! • Acting as the doctor, give everyone the exact same treatment by placing a Band-Aid on their arm. • Repeat this for however many volunteers there are • Lean into the absurdity of creative injuries! • Defend your treatment choice by using the word "equal" and claiming that you are being completely fair because everyone received the exact same treatment. • Students will refute, prompting the "aha moment," that equality does not necessarily indicate fairness. • Wrap up the demonstration by asking what a truly "fair" doctor would do, considering the goal of fixing their injuries. Next, crowdsource (once again) a definition of "fairness." Finally, ask the class if they want a "fair" or "equal" class. The answer should be fair. Note: Instructors are encouraged to use stickers, imagination, or both as a replacement for Band-Aids.



Day 3

- **Core Message:** "Everyone has their own way of communicating, and that's great!"
- **Summary:** This day transitions from general brain differences to focusing specifically on communication. Students learn that sharing thoughts and feelings goes beyond spoken words, helping them build empathy for those who use actions, expressions, or alternative methods to express themselves.

Summary

Materials

1. Projector / TV & Audio (to play book read-aloud and video)
2. Storybook / Read-aloud: [A Day With No Words by Tiffany Hammond](#) or purchase book
3. Video: [Lots of Ways to Be Kind with Julia & Elmo](#)

Check-in (7 mins)

The instructor gathers the class together and then begins pointing at individual students, greeting them. Each student should be welcomed with a different greeting. Some ideas are listed below.

1. Hi!
2. Hello!
3. Hey!
4. Good morning/afternoon!
5. (Give a thumbs-up)
6. Nice to see you!
7. It's great to see you!
8. (A kind smile and pat on the head)
9. How's everything?
10. Good to see you again!
11. Welcome!
12. (just a smile and a wave)

Repeat as long as it seems fit, and then say, "There are so many ways to say hello! Everyone has their own way, and that's okay." To close the check-in activity, ask each student to think of their favorite greeting in their head. On the count of three, ask them all to shout it out/perform it at once!

1

Read book (8 mins)

[A Day With No Words by Tiffany Hammond](#) (read aloud)

2



Day 3 cont.

Discussion + Connection (10 mins)	Questions to ask: 1.The boy in our story doesn't speak. How does he talk to his mommy and share his big thoughts? a. Tablet/computer b. <i>What are some other ways he could communicate?</i> 2.How do you think the boy feels when people in the park don't understand him? 3.What can we do to be a patient, kind friend to someone who communicates differently?	3
Watch video (5 mins)	<u>Lots of Ways to Be Kind with Julia and Elmo</u> (video)	4
Post-Video Discussion (5 mins)	Questions to ask: 1.How did Elmo welcome Vivi? How did Julia welcome Vivi? 2.There are lots of ways to be kind, and each method is just as great as the rest! If Vivi joined our class, how would you show kindness and welcome her?	5



Applying Concepts

Day 4

Time: 40 minutes

- **Core Message:** "Our differences show up in how we live, play, and learn every day, and fairness means helping everyone get what they need."
- **Summary:** This day bridges foundational concepts—like unique brains, equity, and communication styles—and applies them to real-world, everyday scenarios. Through video observation and an active game, students practice recognizing and accommodating diverse needs in a classroom setting.

Summary

Materials

1. Projector / Screen (for Scenario Slideshow)
2. Open Space (for movement/dance activity)
3. Scenario Script & Slides (4 real-world classroom situations)

Opening Review Activity (5 mins)

Say: "To start today, we're going to see what we remember from this week's neurodiversity lessons!" Ask the following questions:

1. What does "neurodiversity" mean?
 - a. All brains are different
2. Does "being fair" mean giving everyone the same thing, or different things?
 - a. Fair means giving everyone what they NEED, not giving everyone the SAME thing.
3. Does everybody communicate in the same way?
 - a. No!

1

Dance Activity (15 mins)

Take the class outside or to an open area of the classroom for another activity demonstrating different thinking!

Play the audio of **this** video:

- Ask each student to start dancing to it "on the count of 3." Let them dance for a bit, then stop.
- Ask the students: "Did everyone dance the exact same, or differently?"
- After their response, ask the students: "Why do you think you all did different dances?"
 - If the kids are stuck, remind them that their brains control their dance moves.

2



Day 4 cont.

- Adapt based on the responses, but overall the answer should be: "As we all learned this week, we all think differently and have different brains - that is why we all did different things when the music came on!"

Skip to a new section of the music video.

- Let them redo the activity once more.
- Teachers can point out and praise specific movements from different kids.
- At the end of these, make sure to say: "All of these dances were really cool, and I thought they were all so interesting! Don't you guys think so too?"

Conclusion:

"As you guys can see, everyone does things differently. We think differently all the time! The fact that our dances were different didn't make them any less amazing. In fact, it would be SO BORING if we always danced the exact same!" → "Differences in what we think or do are what make us cool and interesting."

Scenario Game (20 mins)

- This scenario game will help students synthesize the information that they have learned in the past three days.
- The instructor will display **this** slideshow for the class, and then read scenarios and discussion questions from a script.
 - The script is in the speaker notes of the slideshow and linked **here**—either works as long as the instructor can read the script and the class can simultaneously view the slideshow.
- The correct resolution for each scenario should be clear, but if confusion arises, the answer key is below.

3

Scenario 1: Neither was trying to be mean. Jacob and Amelia should explain their side of the conflict to each other.

Scenario 2: Charlie's accommodations are not equal, but fair because he *needs* the extra time to finish his worksheet.

Scenario 3: It's okay that Eve's preferences are different from her classmates'! Neurodiversity is fun and beautiful.

Scenario 4: Camila didn't intend to ruin Noah's sand castle.



Day 5

- **Core Message:** "Differences in what we think or do are what make us cool and interesting—not bad in any way!"
- **Summary:** The final day is a celebration of individuality and a wrap-up of the week's themes. Students experience firsthand how unique brains naturally interpret things differently through an upbeat dance activity, followed by a reflective drawing project to solidify their commitment to acceptance.

Summary

Materials

1. Music Player / Projector (to play the video)
2. Video: [Lots of Ways to Connect Music Video with Elmo, Julia, and Friends](#)
3. Paper & Crayons / Markers (or Sidewalk Chalk for outdoors)

Intro: Video (5 mins)

Lots of Ways to Connect Music Video with Elmo, Julia, and Friends

1

Ask: Do all friends have to play the same way to have fun with each other?

Activity: Reflective Drawing Project (20 mins)

This activity can be done either with chalk outdoors or on printer paper indoors. Have students complete the prompts below. You may choose from the prompts below or make your own (recommended only do 1-2 prompts)

2

Prompt 1: What Makes You Unique

- Tell students: "Draw one thing you love to do, play, or eat that makes you uniquely YOU."

Prompt 2: Neurodiversity Celebration

- Tell students: "Choose someone sitting at a different table. Draw a playground that you think they and you would both enjoy."

Prompt 3: Practicing Acceptance

- Tell students: "Turn to a partner next to you, share one thing you love to do, and make up your own special 'friendship high-five' or fist-bump together!"



Day 5 cont.

Final Wrap-Up (10 minutes)

Close the week's curriculum with a repeat-after-me, revisiting the week's biggest takeaways.

3

1. Neurodiversity means that all of our brains are different.
2. Neurodiversity is great!
3. Being fair does not always mean that everyone gets the same thing.
4. Fair means giving everyone what they *need*.
5. Everybody communicates differently, and that's okay.
6. We can help our friends feel happy by being kind and inclusive.

Discuss the following questions

- What does neurodiversity mean?
 - All of our brains are different!
- Say: This means that we all think and feel differently. How can we help all of the different brains in this classroom feel happy and loved?
 - Kindness and inclusion!

If you choose to display the day-by-day main message, point them out to your students before concluding this lesson.

Finally, thank your students for learning about neurodiversity for the past week. And thank *you* for participating in our program!

